

Mav and the Virtual Bean-Dip Gauntlet

Maverick woke up with a singular, high-octane craving for an Egg McMuffin. He looked around his room. The Professor Bucktooth doll was missing again, but Mav figured the beaver was either auditing a local dam or trying to haunt a nearby lumberyard.

Mav strolled into the Clovis McDonald's, only to stop dead in his tracks. Behind the counter, standing on a stack of Big Mac boxes and wearing a tiny, grease-stained visor, was the Bucktooth doll. He was frantically flipping eggs with a miniature spatula.

"Professor?" Mav asked, squinting. "Is this part of your 'Beaver Justice' campaign?"

"Maverick! Do not interrupt the assembly line! The structural integrity of this muffin is compromised if the cheese isn't placed at a perfect fifteen-degree angle relative to the Canadian bacon!" the doll squeaked. "I'm earning extra credit toward my 'Structural Fry-Cook' certification! Now, take your muffin and wait for my shift to end. I have found a glitch in the Matrix!"

After the Professor clocked out (which involved him biting the time-clock), they headed back to Mav's room. Mav pulled out his Meta Quest 2 headsets.

"We are playing **Gorilla Tag**, Professor," Mav said, strapping on the goggles. "It's the ultimate test of arm-based momentum."

"Aha! A digital simulation of primate-based structural movement!" Bucktooth shouted, his button eyes glowing inside his own custom-fitted headset.

They spent an hour swinging through the virtual forest, hooting and hollering, until Mav tried to take his headset off. It wouldn't budge. It felt like it was fused to his skin with industrial-grade supernatural adhesive.

"Uh, Professor? I'm stuck in the goggles. I can see my own house, but it's pixelated."

Suddenly, the virtual forest glitched. The sky turned the color of a bruised grape, and **Taffy Stamburger** appeared, floating in mid-air and wearing a digital trenchcoat made of flickering binary code.

"Greetings, monkes," Taffy rasped, his voice echoing in 8-bit. "If you ever want to see your physical bodies again, you must complete the **Stamburger Gauntlet**. Fail, and you'll spend eternity as low-polygon primates!"

"Taffy! This is a violation of the Terms of Service!" the Bucktooth doll shrieked, his virtual avatar (a beaver wearing a top hat) waving its arms.

Challenge One: The Great Cloud Race. "First to the giant floating banana wins!" Taffy announced. Mav and the Professor swung their arms wildly, but Taffy simply unzipped his trenchcoat and used it like a hang-glider, soaring past them. "I HAVE FLIGHT CAPABILITIES, LADDIE!" Taffy yelled. "STAIRS ARE FOR SUCKERS!" Mav and Bucktooth lost the race by three miles.

Challenge Two: The Doritos Dust-Off. A giant, virtual bag of Nacho Cheese Doritos appeared. "Eat the most chips in thirty seconds," Taffy commanded. Taffy began shoveling chips into his face, but he was no match for a beaver who had once chased a wheel of cheese down a hill. Bucktooth's felt mouth became a vacuum of orange dust. "AHA! MY GULLET HAS THE VOLUMETRIC CAPACITY OF A SMALL CULVERT!" Bucktooth roared, winning the challenge by a landslide of crumbs.

Challenge Three: The Tag of Silence. "Tag me if you can!" Mav yelled. Because Bucktooth was a puppet in the real world, his virtual avatar suddenly went limp whenever Mav wasn't touching the doll. Bucktooth flopped on the ground like a soggy pancake. Mav simply walked over and poked him. "I win!" Mav cheered. "THAT IS A STRUCTURAL DISADVANTAGE!" the Professor screamed from the floor.

The Final Challenge: The Nerf Battle of Destiny. Taffy snapped his fingers. A random, barefoot kid with a bowl cut appeared next to him. "This is my teammate," Taffy announced. "His name is **Cheap Whiskey**." "Wait, what kind of name is that?" Mav asked. "I don't know," Cheap Whiskey shrugged, holding a Nerf blaster. "My parents are very creative and also very tired."

The battle began! Darts flew everywhere. Mav and Bucktooth took cover behind a digital dumpster. Just as Taffy was about to deliver a finishing blow, Cheap Whiskey dropped his blaster. "I gotta go," the kid said. "Where?!" Taffy yelled. "The virtual bathroom. I drank too much digital juice. Peace out!" Cheap Whiskey vanished into a loading screen.

Mav and Bucktooth peppered Taffy with foam darts until the genie surrendered.

POP.

The headsets fell off. Mav and the Professor were back in the bedroom. They immediately ran to the kitchen.

"I need sugar to offset the digital trauma!" Mav cried. They headed to *The Scoop*, where Mav got a double-scoop of **Meme Mint** (which was neon blue and tasted like internet rumors). The Professor, now back in his doll form, ordered a cone of **Log-Flavored Swirl** (which was basically just frozen sawdust and maple syrup).

"Toodaloo, Maverick!" the doll laughed, covered in syrup. "The digital realm is no match for a well-fed rodent!"

They laughed the afternoon away, completely unaware that inside the Quest 2, Taffy Stamburger was still floating in the purple void with a returning Cheap Whiskey.

"Seriously, kid," Taffy groaned, looking at the time. "How am I supposed to get my son **Laffy** to school if I'm trapped in a gorilla simulation? My trenchcoat is losing pixels!"

"Want to see my pet rock?" Cheap Whiskey asked, holding up a floating triangle.